Serialization as Situation. A Formal-Situational Account of Serial Verb Constructions

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Abstract:

This paper examines Serial Verb Constructions (SVCs) from a new interdisciplinary perspective by linking linguistic analysis models with the sociological Theory of the Formal Situation (FS). At its core, by re-evaluating cross-linguistic data through this novel lens, the study offers a critique of established, purely morphosyntactic definitions—specifically Martin Haspelmath's feature-based approach—arguing that such models often neglect pragmatic context and situational embedding.

The paper posits that linguistic structures do not primarily follow an innate grammatical code; instead, they emerge as representations of universal situational dimensions: space, time, and quantity. The Principle of the Tendency towards Unity is introduced as a fundamental motive for human action and linguistic expression. It suggests that actors strive to preserve and expand their "essential units," perceiving situations primarily as unities.

Based on this theoretical framework, an alternative definition of SVCs is proposed. This definition emphasizes the absence of temporal gaps and the perception of a "single situation" alongside criteria such as the use of independent verbs and the lack of linking elements. From a sociological standpoint, SVCs are interpreted as highly efficient descriptions of frequent everyday situations grounded in shared background expectations and a "restricted code". Finally, the cross-linguistic distribution of these constructions is explained through the concept of path dependence: once established, these efficient linguistic structures are maintained because switching to alternative codes would incur significant social and cognitive costs.

The study concludes that a view of the "formal situation" provides new explanatory models for the universal development of grammar, suggesting that linguistic categories are a necessary consequence of the formal features of the situations they represent.

1. Background

1.1. Motivation

This study builds upon the findings of my prior research, which explored the constitutive requirements of a "minimal situation" through the development of the Theory of the Formal Situation (FS). An important insight of this foundational research was that natural languages already function as highly sophisticated systems capable of descriptively capturing any given situation.

This raises the central research question: Do structural similarities across different languages exist because the situations they describe can be formally traced back to universal dimensions—specifically space, time, and quantity? The objective of this work is to

investigate whether and to what extent linguistic constructs can be modeled as direct representations of these formal situations.
To provide an empirical focus, this study examines Serial Verb Constructions (SVCs). This interdisciplinary approach allows for a dual perspective:

1. Modeling SVCs: Analyzing how these specific sentence constructions can be represented as formal situations within the FS framework.

2. Theoretical Evaluation: Determining whether the application of FS Theory—by looking beyond traditional morphosyntactic criteria—can offer new analytical categories not only for the study of serial verb constructions, but for language as a whole.

In doing so, this thesis seeks to bridge the gap between sociological action theories and linguistic analysis models—such as those discussed by Haspelmath (2015), Lovestrand (2021) or Langacker (2012)—to argue that grammatical structures are a necessary consequence of the formal features of the situations they are designed to represent.

1.2. Definitions of SVC

In his paper "Serial Verb Constructions" (SVC), Joseph Lovestrand (2021) compares different theoretical approaches to classifying SVCs. He starts from a very general definition: "In a serial verb construction (SVC), two or more verbs combine in a single clause without any morphosyntactic marking of linking or subordination" (Lovestrand 2021:109). He sees the fundamental problems with this definition in determining the nature of verbs, establishing their clausal nature and delimiting morphosyntactic features. SVCs are not limited to a specific part of the world, they are more common in the languages of West Africa, Southeast Asia and the Pacific.

He currently sees two different theoretical directions for classifying serial verb construction (cf. Lovestrand 2021:124ff). (1) SVCs in generative syntax and (2) SVCs in comparative syntax:

(1) **Generative approaches** can be divided into Chomskyan analysis methods of syntax and analysis methods outside of Chomskyan syntax (constraint-based generative theories).
Generative approaches try to match verbs with their arguments and determine semantic roles. The problem in SVCs is generally that there are an insufficient number of arguments for the verbs.
Although generative methods are suitable for enabling cross-linguistic comparisons, it is criticized that the narrow definition excludes many SVCs. The problem of defining features arises again.

(2) **Comparative approaches** can also be roughly divided into two groups: (a) Arbitrary Restrictive Approach to define SVCs and (b) Prototype Approach:

(a) The **arbitrary-restrictive approach** is represented by Haspelmath, for example. He suggests that linguists should define characteristics of SVCs for cross-linguistic analysis. If these prove useful, then the definition makes sense (cf. Haspelmath 2016). Arbitrarily restrictive approaches to define SVCs can be very useful for quantitative cross-linguistic studies.
Haspelmath's SVC definition (2016:6): (1) Productive schematic construction (2) Monoclausal (3) Independent verbs (4) No linking element (5) No predicate-argument relationship between the verbs.
Additionally, Haspelmath identified 10 generalizations that apply to all SVCs.
Problems: Beside arbitrariness, the arbitrary-restrictive approach assumes that SVCs that do not fit the schema fall into a typological gap (problem of delimiting well-defined multiverb constructions) (Lovestrand 2021:125).

(b) The prototype approach is defined more generally and allows exceptions to the SVC definition. However, it also has the fundamental problem of delimitation because it is necessary to determine which exceptions are permissible.

Lovestrand points out that complex sentences cannot be described by overgeneralization and classification into a handful of categories (SVCs, clausechaining, cosubordination, conjunctive constructions, and consecutive constructions). There are other additional aspects and gradations that have not yet been considered. However, Lovestrand maintains that clause is a fundamentally universal concept that needs to be further investigated in order to find out how events are represented in the grammar (cf. Lovestrand 2021:126).

1.3. Theory of the Formal Situation

In linguistics, the clause or event is often described as the smallest coherent unit of meaning, such as a sentence. This contrasts with the term social situation, which is often used in a similar way. I therefore investigated the question of how a situation can be defined in a generally valid way.
I asked myself whether there is a minimum number of dimensions and rules to describe any situation.

The following is a provisional definition:

(1) **Situation name** (varies depending on standpoint)

(2) **Situation elements** (internal knowledge elements ◑, external knowledge elements ▢
Elements of knowledge can themselves be situations. The principle of self-referentiality applies.

(3) Dimensions (space, time, quantity)
- **Space:** The spatial world of perception and imagination, spatial aspects
- **Time:** world time, inner subjective duration of time, aspects of time
- **Quantity:** Number of knowledge elements in the situation or

exchange situations in the time interval. This dimension determines aspects of power.

(4) **Exchange dimension** "⇒" (effect/perception, give/take, communication, interaction,...). This dimension describes exchange relationships between knowledge elements that can change the situation.
- Exchange is triggered by an impulse in a social situation (see principle of the tendency to unity)
- Exchange is reciprocal or one-sided in terms of viewpoints and perspectives oriented

(5) **Standpoint** 🔸, **Perspective/Focus** ▭ on situational elements (one must assume at least one actor who can enter into an exchange relationship)

(6) Principle of the <u>tendency towards unity</u> (motive) (essential unity, pos/neg. emotions, preserving or expanding impulse)

Explanation to point 6: Is there a generalizable motive that applies to all situations?

Alfred Schütz (2003:88;188) named the "finiteness of man" as a general motive for our actions. He derived daily and life plans from this, which, however, cannot be generalized (do not apply to all situations in the same way). The principle of the "tendency towards unity" closes this gap. It applies to all situations and also to all living beings.

Tendency towards Unity:
(1) You see each situation as a unity.
(2) The principle of the tendency towards unity means that essential situational units are preserved and expanded. In this order.

It comprises three parts:

- **Essential unit (EU):** EU are those situations that are important to us (body, health, family, world view, attitude, mindset, etc.)
  Essential units are formed through proximity (spatial, temporal, frequency; essential units become conscious above all during primary socialization)

- If essential units are threatened, actors react with a **preservation impulse**. Threats can be perceived rationally and emotionally (emotions such as fear, anger, rage, hatred).

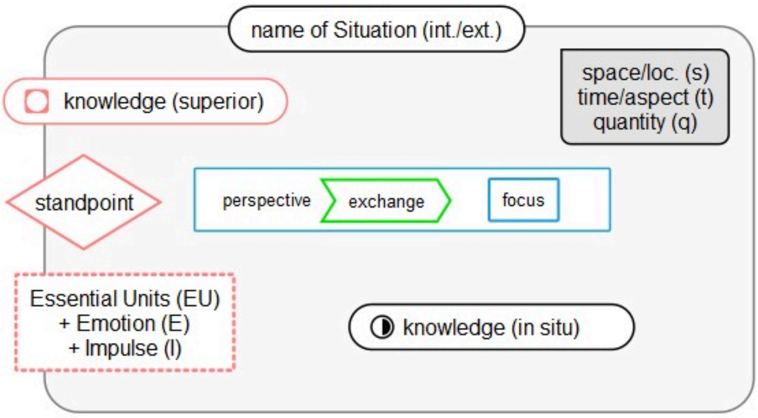
- Basically, actors try to expand essential units (**expansion impulse**). Successful expansion is experienced as a positive emotion (joy, happiness).

One example:
We cannot arbitrarily link our existing knowledge with objects; knowledge and perception are mutually dependent.
On a walk, a geologist notices stones, a botanist notices plants. Both integrate this perception into their essential units for this situation (prior knowledge) and understand these elements of the situation through this process (expansion impulse). However, if a snake

comes into view at the edge of the path, its essential situational unit changes and its body or health is in danger. The essential situational unit comes from the individual, but is often activated by the situation (preservation impulse).

The elements of the formal units are summarized in Figure 1.

Fig. 1: “Formal Situation”



The following analysis assumes that linguistic concepts basically describe or explain formal situations. For example, pragmatics would mean the classification of the given situation into other situations. Semantics is mainly concerned with which formal situation a linguistic utterance represents. And forms of grammar, syntax, phonetics, gestures are consistent means within a language system to create formal situations (the rules used correspond to intersubjective agreements).
In a sense, Langacker's notion of the baseline can be read as an implicit description of a minimal formal situation: a propositional core that is neutral with respect to speaker, context, and modality – and thus reducible to its purely formal dimensions (cfg. Langacker 2012).

2. Material, method, aims

SVC sentences from different languages are used as research material to show the breadth of the topic to be investigated. However, due to the scope and time available, it is not possible to guarantee representativeness for the selection. In fact, mainly sentences from Haspelmath's (2016) paper on serial verb constructions were used. In order to investigate the questions of this thesis, the concept of the formal situation is used as a research method. In addition, appropriate theories are referred to when necessary (such as path dependence theory).

Questions:
- How can serial verb constructions be represented as formal situations?
- Why do SVCs occur in some languages and not in others (attempt at a sociological explanation)?
- Minimal SVC-definition from sociological point of view, following the criticism of Haspelmath's approach.

3. Analysis

3.1 Approach

I examined the paper "The serial verb construction: Comparative concept and cross-linguistic generalizations" by Martin Haspelmath (2015) to find out to what extent SVC sentences can be represented with the help of the theory of the formal situation and whether the approach of a comparative programme for serial verb constructions is tenable from this theoretical perspective. Therefore, I first tried to represent individual sentences in terms of the formal situation and examine the result. In the next step, I analyzed Haspelmath's definition of SVCs (Haspelmath, 2015:5ff), as well as his generalizations §4 (Haspelmath, 2015:16ff) and looked for counterexamples. I then present my own definition of an SVC definition in the sense of the formal definition, which is opposed to the concept of generative grammar in that it does not see an inherent grammatical-syntactic structure in language constructs, but rather understands language as a representation of the formal situation. I therefore do not assume an "innate cognitive code for grammar (universal grammar)" (Haspelmath, 2015:3), but from the fact that languages are forced to correspond to a few formal dimensions and features of situations. Because languages have to represent situations, languages produce grammatical concepts that are internally consistent and comparable across languages.

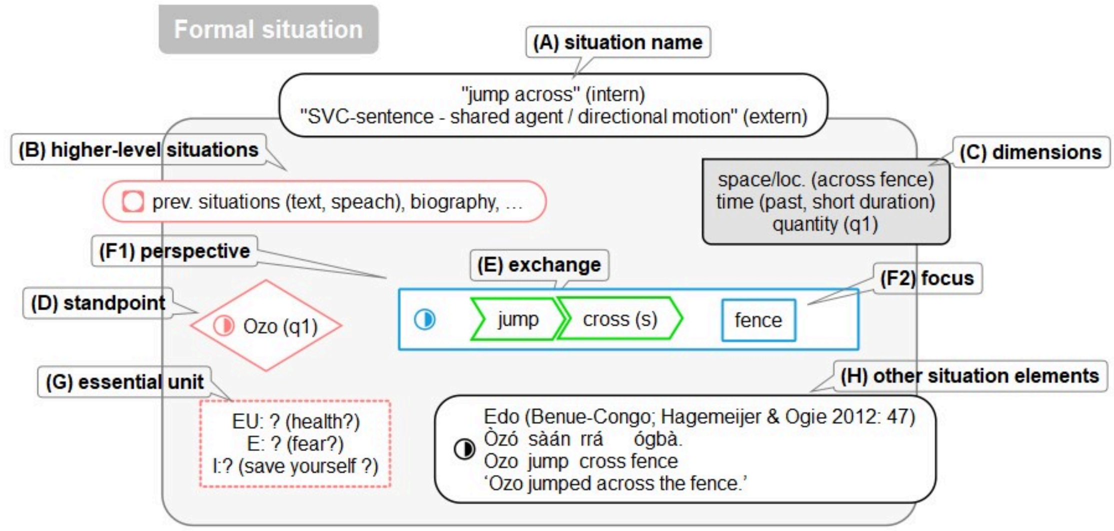
3.2 SVC sentences as a formal situation

Haspelmath presented some examples of serial verb constructions for his SVC definition at the beginning, which show that there is often an agent or object division in SVC sentences. The following example (1) comes from Edo, a language in Benue-Congo (Benue-Congo; Hagemeijer & Ogie 2012: 47).

```
(1)   Edo (Benue-Congo; Hagemeijer & Ogie 2012: 47)
      Òzó  sàán  rrá   ógbà.
      Ozo  jump  cross fence
      'Ozo jumped across the fence.'
```

I have tried to represent the sentence schematically as a formal situation (Fig. 2):

Fig. 2: Formal situation to sentence ‘jump across’



I have marked all the essential elements of the formal situation (FS) with letters and labeled them by name.
The central content is represented by the internal point of view D (Ozo) and its perspective F1, as well as the exchange E (jump, cross) and the focus F2 (fence). The situation dimensions C (space, time and quantity) can be derived from the linguistic utterance. Space/place: Actor was obviously standing in front of a fence and jumped over it; time: past, time accent: short duration; quantity: 1 actor, 1 fence.
However, the essential unit G with emotion and impulse cannot usually be reconstructed from an isolated sentence. It is therefore not possible to determine whether it is a preserving impulse and negative emotion or an expanding impulse with positive emotion. In this respect, one can only make assumptions (health, fear, save oneself). Surrounding situations B such as the immediate context, what was previously said or one's own experiences are not transmitted.
Haspelmath sees from an external linguist's point of view that the verbs share an agent and that one verb is a movement verb and the other is transitive. From the FS point of view, one could postulate a new verb jump-cross, since a continuous exchange action was performed. Why no such verb has become established could be explained by the low frequency of the action.

In the next example (2) by Haspelmath (2015:3), the verb type changes from transitive to intransitive. In the representation of a formal situation Fig. 2, however, it is essential that this example deals with 2 different situations - a current and a future one from the actor's point of view.

```
(2) Hoan (Tuu, Botswana; Collins 2002: 4)
    Ma   ‖oe   na   ka   ‖hoam-‖hoam tca.
    1SG still AUX SUB jog          come
   ‘while I was still coming jogging’
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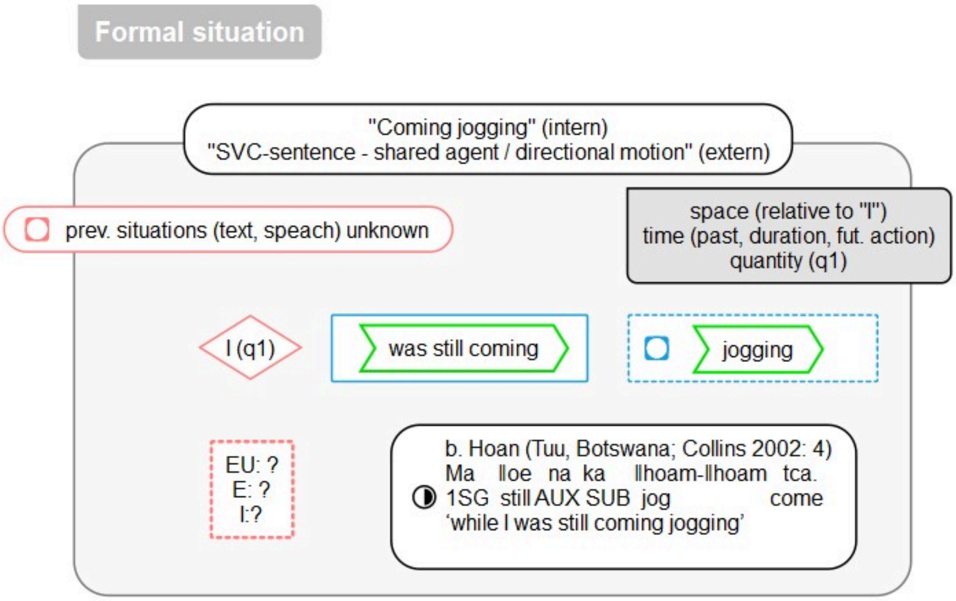
Fig. 3: “coming jogging”



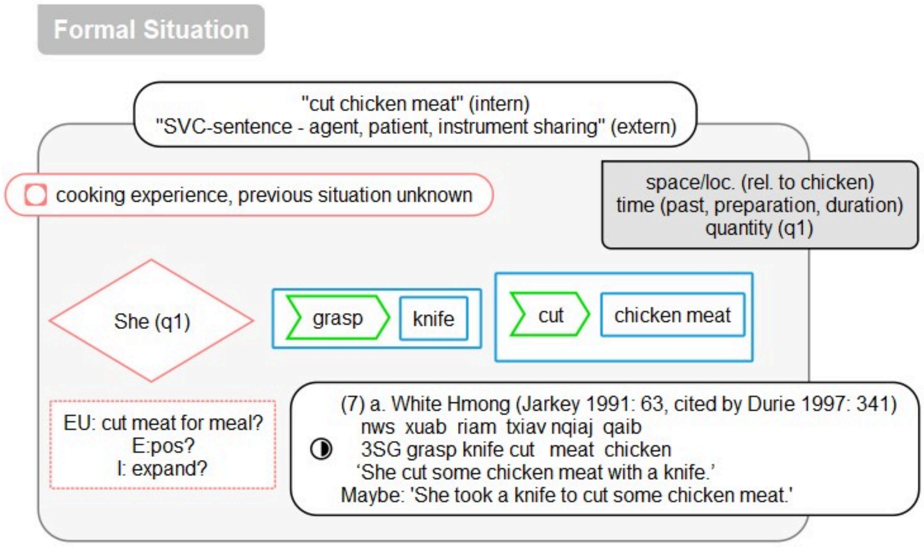
It is also important to mention here that no essential units can be identified that justify an emotion and an impulse to act. It would be desirable for the context to be conveyed in linguistic-analytical investigations of sentences. However, it turns out that this SVC represents 2 situations, a present and a future situation. From a linguistic perspective (Haspelmath), however, the focus is on the verb in motion. It can be seen that a sociological (FS) and a linguistic perspective show different results.

According to Haspelmath (2015:4), another example (3) involves agent sharing; the patient and instrument are also shared.

```
(3) White Hmong (Jarkey 1991: 63, cited by Durie 1997: 341)
    nws xuab  riam  txiav nqiaj qaib
    3SG grasp knife cut   meat  chicken
   'She cut some chicken meat with a knife.'
```

If one examines the sentence according to FS, it looks as if the "cutting of the meat with a knife" is not emphasized but the "grasp knife" represents a separate situation of "turning" to the subsequent situation "cutting of the meat". See Fig. 4.

Fig. 4: “cut chicken meat”



The essential unit can only be guessed at - for a meal or for sale? What is crucial in this context, however, is that the English translation emphasizes the cutting of the meat with a knife, although this process is usually done with a knife. How is it possible to emphasize an object (perspective) in an SVC through verb order or object reference? In other words, can serial verb constructions be used to emphasize special or different processes in general situations?

As a first summary, with regard to representations of formal situations in languages, we can say that this is possible in principle, but with the following remarks:

- Isolated sentences usually do not provide complete information (essential unit, surrounding situations cannot be determined)
- By presenting the situation from a standpoint and perspective of a formal situation, new insights can sometimes be gained that differ from the linguistic perspective
- Due to the number of cases examined, it is not possible to make a conclusive assessment of the use of FS for language description

3.3 SVC definitions at Haspelmath

Following introductory examples, Haspelmath tries to give a definition of serial verb constructions: "*A serial verb construction is a monoclausal construction consisting of multiple independent verbs with no element linking them and with no predicate-argument relationship between the verbs*" (Haspelmath, 2015:6). A distinction must be made between 5 definition elements: (a) construction (b) monoclausal (c) independent verbs (d) no linking element (e) no predicate-argument relationship between the verb.

a) Productive Construction

Haspelmath believes that a serial verb construction must be a "productive schematic construction" (Haspelmath 2015:6). The meaning must be determined from the meaning of the parts as well as the construction. Non-compositional (idiomatic) verb constructions would not be included (Haspelmath 2015:6).ff
I agree with Haspelmath that idiomatic sentences cannot fall under an SVC construction since they represent a situation as a whole. However, it is problematic to claim that the meaning can only be derived from the parts and the construction. Because without surrounding situations (and essential unity), the meaning of an SVC sentence, as Examples 1-3 show, cannot be clearly determined. The construction also depends on the environment and cannot be completely reconstructed from the parts. This is also explicitly mentioned by Haspelmath: "*The precise semantic-pragmatic conditions for combining different kinds of verbs have been much less described than the morphosyntactic properties of the resulting constructions"* (Haspelmath 2015:7).

For example, Haspelmath (2015:7) points out the Japanese serial verb pattern presented by Nishiyama (1998: 175, 196) in (4a). This admits that an analogous representation of (4b) is not possible, without saying why:

```
(4) a. John-ga    niwatori-o naguri-korosi-ta.
        John-NOM   chicken    beat-kill-PST
       'John beat a chicken and killed it.'

    b. *John-ga  sushi-o   tukuri-tabe-ta.
       John-NOM  sushi-ACC  make-eat-PST
      ('John made sushi and ate it.')
```

In my opinion, the difference between 4a and 4b is that although both represent 2 situations, the situations in 4b do not necessarily have to follow one another. There can be a long break between making the sushi and eating it. You have to know the cultural context at the time the language construct was created. I know from my parents' house that a table prayer is said before meals. What is much more important, however, is the fact that sushi was originally a method of preserving freshwater fish (cf. Rossbach 2006). Naturally, there was a longer gap between preparation and consumption.
Therefore, for an SVC construction, I would require that the situations represented in SVC sentences must immediately follow each other or even overlap.

To summarize, it can be said that in SVC constructions, in addition to the elements, more attention must be paid to the context and it seems to be the case that the situations depicted must not have any gaps (they must overlap or immediately follow each other). We can see that a design definition (productive construction) from the parts is not useful. You even have to look at the context in which it was created.

b) Monoclausal

Haspelmath (2015:8), like most other work in the area of serial verb construction, calls for monocausality for SVC sentences. However, individual sentences are not clearly defined and often depend on language-specific circumstances (cf. Butt 2010:57 cit. Haspelmath 2015:8). Haspelmath sees this problem and equates monocausal with "simple negation", i.e. "*that in a serial verb construction there is only one way to form the negation, usually with scope across all verbs*" (Haspelmath 2015:8).

Haspelmath then gives an example of monoclausality, which Larson (2010) has classified as an example of biclausality (5a-b):

```
(5) a. *Ɔ        kɛɛ   man  ngatɛ   di.
       3SG.SUBJ grill NEG  peanuts eat
     ('She doesn't roast peanuts and eats them.')

   b. *Ɔ        kɛɛn  ngatɛ   di  man.
      3SG.SUBJ grill peanuts eat NEG
    ('She roasts peanuts and doesn't eat them.')
```

In fact, the verbs in 5a + 5b are negated separately and you can see that the meaning changes. So these would be biclausal and not as Haspelmath thinks: monocausal. Biclausality can also be assumed above all because 2 different situations are represented, which also "make sense" in their negation. Nevertheless, the un-negated form can be understood as SVC if it represents a very common everyday situation (roasting and eating peanuts).

In my opinion, the demand for contextless monoclausality does not take the SVC definition one step further, because it cannot explain why it is needed in terms of content. I start from the assumption that SVC sentences are used because they depict a frequent everyday situation, because the verbs represent a continuous course of action and because the construction is efficient.
Simple negation is also problematic because only isolated sentences are considered and not the surrounding situation. This means that there can be grammatically independent negations, but only one variant is pragmatically meaningful, which is perhaps the case with Larson (2010).

Summary “mono-clausity”:

- One can understand (5a) as a situation, especially if the un-negated form occurs frequently (norm action).
- Example (5b) on the other hand sounds like 2 situations, depending on the context. Maybe she didn't eat them because she wanted to sell them? (=> exception to the norm action)
- This also means that a simple negation does not determine monoclausality, because the context is not considered. Haspelmath's point can be omitted.

c) Independent verbs

Haspelmath (2015:12for his comparative concept as follows:
“*An independent verb is a form that can express a dynamic event without any special coding in predication function and that can occur in a non-elliptical utterance without another verb*.”

I can agree with this definition even if the term “dynamic event” is unfortunate. A verb can certainly express an inner state of being because, from the FS perspective, it represents the exchange dimension. The non-dynamics, i.e. the equivalence, also represents an exchange relationship, which is then interpreted as an assignment (term formation).

d) No linking element

The absence of a linking element in serial verb constructions is cited as one of the most common characteristics for them to fall into this category (cf. Haspelmath 2015:13).
In principle, I agree with the definition type "no linking element", but Haspelmath's (2015:13) formulation "*Thus, it is safest to regard any element that occurs in a multiverb construction, does not occur outside of a multi-verb construction, and does not have some clear other meaning (such as tense, aspect, negation) as a linking element*" does not seem very practicable to me in the analysis of SVC sentences.
I would describe linking elements more clearly: All elements that contribute nothing to the finiteness of the verb group are linking elements. They should not occur in SVC sentences.

e) No predicate-argument relation between the verbs

As a final definition criterion, Haspelmath (2015:14) states that SVC sentences "NOT INVOLVE A PREDICATE ARGUMENT RELATION". In fact, Haspelmath would exclude sentences of the following form (6a+b) from SVC types:

```
(6) a. Samoan (Mosel 2004: 272)
     'ou te  lee  iloa  'a'au
     I   TAM not  know  swim
    'I don't know how to swim.'

    b. Eastern Kayah Li (Tibeto-Burman; Solnit 2006: 153)
    vɛ̄  kha     ʔírɛ dɯ         ʌ́
    1SG promise work own.accord NEW.SITUATION
   'I promise to work myself.'
```

In my opinion, both sentences (6a+b) are SVC sentences because they are probably said frequently, i.e. they represent a common everyday situation and also meet the criteria of "no linking elements" and "independent verbs". A possible complementarity or causality relationship must not exclude these examples. Furthermore: Haspelmath allows such constructions in generalization 5.

In addition, the situations shown in 6a+b do not have a time gap.

3.4 Generalizations in Haspelmath

Haspelmath (cf. 2015:16ff) describes 10 generalizations that apply to SVC sentences, whereby this is a compilation of generalizations that have already been described in the literature. He emphasizes that he makes no claim to originality and also did not have the opportunity to conduct extensive empirical studies to test these generalizations. Haspelmath even found isolated exceptions for generalizations 6 and 7 (Haspelmath 2015:18f).

For the generalization 5 *"If a SVC expresses a cause-effect relationship, or a sequential event, the order of the two verbs is tense-iconic, i.e. the cause verb precedes the effect verb, and the verb that expresses the earlier event precedes the verb that expresses the later event* (Durie 1997:§4, Aikhenvald 2006: 16, 21, 28-29) there is, in my opinion, also an exception (1d in Haspelmath):

```
(7)Tariana (Arawakan; Aikhenvald 2006: 5)
   nhuta    nu-thaketa-ka          di-ka-pidana
   1SG.take 1SG-cross.CAUS-SUBORD 3SG-see-REM.PST
  'He saw that I took it across.'
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Aikhenvald's example (7) seems to contradict generalization 5: one must first "see" in order to determine that it was "taken" "cross" [it may be possible to argue simultaneity; however, an event cannot be observed retrospectively]. In order to be able to judge the whole process one must first see; one cannot argue: the cause is "crossing" and the effect is "seen", because it is about a completed action that is observed]. Compare observation in science. In example (7) "cross" comes before "see". Always assuming that in Tariana you read from left to right.

Not unproblematic in this context: Haspelmath has actually ruled out this generalization under definition point 5 (reciprocal predication of verbs). His argumentation can therefore not be traced back to disjunctive positions.

4. My SVC definition

The five definition points and the 10 generalizations are, in my opinion, too complicated to classify SVCs and make comparative language studies. This is because these definitions and generalizations are not always disjunctive, are too extensive and exclusively attempt to categorize the nature of SVCs via grammatical-syntactic phenomena. Hence my approach, which includes both grammatical-syntactic features and semantic-pragmatic criteria.

4.1 Grammatical-syntactic requirements for SVCs

a) No time gaps (single situation)

   Each verb potentially represents a partial action or a sub-situation. It is only an SVC construction if the process represented by the verbs has no gaps (partial actions must either overlap or immediately follow one another). This fact may not be determinable solely through syntactic-grammatical analysis. An SVC sentence must be experienced as a single situation.

b) Independent verbs

   I adopt the definition from Haspelmath (2015:12): "*An independent verb is a form that can express a dynamic event without any special coding in predication function and that can occur in a non-elliptical utterance without another verb*."
   However, this formal independence remains secondary to how the situation is perceived as a single unit, as coherence is fundamentally supported by the actors' implicit knowledge and shared background expectations.

c) No connecting elements

   All elements that do not contribute to the finiteness of the verb group are connecting elements. These elements should not appear in SVC sentences.

4.2 Semantic-pragmatic theses for SVCs

Thesis 1: SVCs describe common everyday situations for which there is a shared understanding.

Common everyday situations are characterized, among other things, by the fact that actors have common background expectations (cf. Garfinkel 2020:88ff). These common superordinate situations give actors the opportunity to evoke a common understanding with just a few signs or gestures, because missing information is supplemented by the participants in the same way. Basil Bernstein (1977) takes a similar view, speaking of a restricted code in this context. SVCs can represent situations without having to resort to an elaborate code. Complex (abstract) terms and situations cannot be clearly defined with SVCs. For example, you can say the following SVC sentences in German: "Sie geht eislaufen", "Er kommt essen", "Sie geht tanzen". If you replace just one verb with a non-everyday verb, the information becomes incomprehensible; "Er geht kommunizieren", "Sie kommt transponieren", "Er geht entwickeln".

Thesis 2: A serial verb constriction is an efficient description of a situation.

By simply stringing together verbs, combined everyday situations can be described economically (see also Thesis 1). This economic principle states that language tends to dispense with superfluous material (cf. Blumenthal-Dramé/Kortmann 2013:293f).
So why are there languages that hardly use SVCs? I think that the fact of shared understanding is even more important. If you have developed grammatical-syntactic structures that you know with certainty that they produce a common understanding of the situation, then you will not leave this path without necessity. Switching to other language structures also comes with costs. The price is to establish an understanding of the situation with new structures and to abandon previously established structures. This phenomenon is described in economics and social sciences with the theory of path dependence (cf. Beyer 2022).

Corresponding studies still need to be carried out to validate this SVC definition. Both the semantic-syntactic presuppositions and the semantic-pragmatic theses require future research and must be empirically tested.

5. Conclusion

The representations of SVC sentences in the form of the Formal Situation have proven to be quite fruitful. It has been shown that isolated sentences do not produce complete formal situations - there is a lack of contextual information. This also suggests the need to provide sentences with additional information for linguistic analysis (e.g. in the form of FS). Otherwise, one runs the risk of relying exclusively on grammatical-semantic criteria and thus making false statements. New insights can be gained by presenting the situation via standpoint and perspective, because a situational unity of sentences is absolutely essential. However, further studies, especially of an empirical nature, are necessary for a conclusive assessment of the use of FS.
In the examination of Haspelmath's SVC definition, some problematic assumptions were discovered. For example, the requirement of a productive construction for the SVC definition is of no additional benefit - every sentence and every term is a (productive) construction (because of changing context). have to be defined to determine whether it is an SVC construction. The requirement of monoclausality is not a helpful prerequisite for serial verb constructions, if it is based on the criterion of simple negation. Negation is problematic because only isolated sentences are considered and not the surrounding situation. This means that there can be grammatically independent negations, but only one variant is pragmatically meaningful. In addition, individual events (multi-clausality in the sentence) can be understood semantically-pragmatically as one event, as was shown in the analysis of FS. Thus, the demand for monoclausality is not tenable from a grammatical-syntactic perspective. Haspelmath's demand that there should be no predicate-argument relationship between the verbs is incomprehensible insofar as, on the one hand, all SVC criteria apply

and, on the other hand, the SVC construction can always be replaced by another sentence type. In addition, a counterexample for generalization 5 (cause-effect relationship) was found.

According to my definition, grammatical-semantic definition criteria are "no time gaps (single situation)", "independent verbs" and "no linking elements". In addition, there are semantic-pragmatic criteria such as "SVC sentences represent frequent everyday situations" and "SVC is an efficient description of such a situation". This should make it possible to determine serial verb combinations across languages. An overlap with other sentence constructions is not a reason for exclusion, because formal situations can be created by many linguistic means. Based on my definition, SVC sentences are rather an indication of social usage. Elaborated and unambiguous constructions are not required to the same extent in every lifeworld. In addition, in my view, path dependency is a criterion that should not be underestimated in terms of how the grammar and semantics of a particular language ultimately develop.
Noam Chomsky assumed that humans are capable of language for genetic reasons, in contrast to other species (innate universal grammar) (cf. Behrens/Pfänder 2013:232). The theory of FS now claims that grammatical and syntactic structures often develop in a similar way because they have to meet the criteria of a formal situation. Incidentally, FS applies to all living beings.

6. References

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